

Continents

The Earth today is made up of seven continents. They lie on huge slabs of rock called tectonic plates that are constantly moving. Hundreds of millions of years ago, there was just one massive stretch of land on Earth. Over time, as the plates either crashed into each other or broke apart, the land separated to form continents.

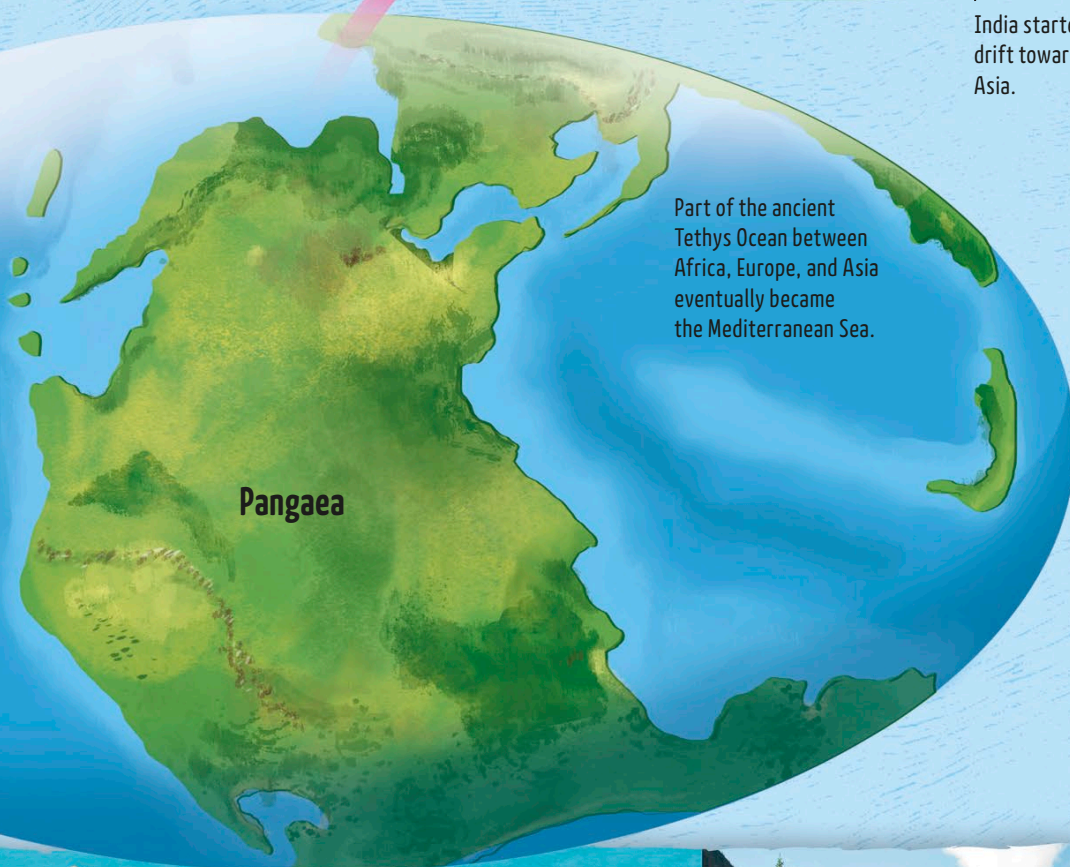


South America and Africa drifted apart as the Atlantic Ocean started to open up.

India started to drift toward Asia.

One continent

Roughly 320–200 million years ago, there was a single area of land called Pangaea. This giant landmass, or supercontinent, was surrounded by ocean.



Part of the ancient Tethys Ocean between Africa, Europe, and Asia eventually became the Mediterranean Sea.

Fossils Geologists studying fossilized plants and animals found similarities between those in South America and Africa. This helped them figure out that they once lived together on a supercontinent.



The Rockies This spectacular mountain range in North America was formed by Pacific Ocean plates sliding under the continental North American plate.

